

Google Ads Campaign Launch Checklist

A practical pre-launch review of goals, targeting, ads, landing pages, measurement, budget, policies, and the details that determine whether a campaign is ready to run.

Understand the situation first.

Use evidence, not assumptions, to decide what to do next.

Built as a working checklist, not a promise of campaign performance.

Before the campaign goes live

A campaign can be technically enabled long before it is actually ready. The point of this checklist is to catch the gaps that are easiest to miss when everyone is focused on getting the ads launched. Work through the sections in order, mark what is confirmed, and leave a note where a decision is still open.

Launch rule: do not treat a completed setup screen as proof that the underlying strategy, landing page, or measurement is sound. Google Ads can deliver traffic to a poorly defined offer just as easily as a well-defined one.

1. Business objective and conversion definition

- Write the business outcome the campaign is expected to influence: qualified leads, booked appointments, purchases, calls, store visits, or another concrete result.
- Define the action that represents real value to the business. A page view or button click may be useful to observe without being the action the campaign should optimize toward.
- Confirm the funnel after the ad click: what does the person do next, and who owns that step?
- Decide whether the first campaign is intended to learn, generate leads, generate sales, or support an already-proven offer. Write the answer down.
- Define what would count as a useful result and what would count as a warning sign.
- Identify constraints: geography, service capacity, inventory, hours, sales response time, seasonal demand, or legal/policy restrictions.

2. Account and campaign foundation

- Correct Google Ads account, billing profile, time zone, and currency are confirmed.
- Campaign objective and campaign type match the intended customer journey. Do not choose a campaign type simply because it is the newest or most heavily recommended option.
- Campaign name is descriptive enough that another person can understand market, offer, location, and purpose without opening the campaign.
- Networks, locations, languages, devices, schedules, and other settings have been deliberately reviewed rather than left at defaults.
- Location targeting reflects the actual service area. Review presence/interest options carefully when local intent matters.
- Campaign-level exclusions and account-level controls have been reviewed where applicable.
- Budget is stated in relation to the business objective and expected traffic, not just as an arbitrary daily number.

3. Search targeting and keyword structure

Google Ads currently supports broad, phrase, and exact keyword matching. Broad match is the default for new keywords; phrase and exact provide progressively more steering over the meaning and intent of searches. Negative keywords can be used to exclude unwanted searches. The important question is not which match type is universally "best," but whether the chosen targeting gives the campaign a sensible way to learn while protecting against clearly irrelevant traffic.

Review	What to verify
Keyword intent	Each keyword or theme represents a service, product, problem, or intent the business actually wants.

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Ad-group structure	Keywords grouped together can be served by the same landing-page promise and ad messaging.
Match types	Broad/phrase/exact choices are intentional and consistent with the campaign data, bidding approach, and tolerance for query expansion.
Negative keywords	Known irrelevant themes, jobs, free/seeking information, unrelated locations, competitors, or other exclusions are documented where appropriate.
Search terms plan	Someone owns review of actual queries and the process for adding negatives, refining themes, and improving ad relevance.

4. Responsive search ads and assets

Responsive search ads can use multiple headlines and descriptions to create combinations. Google currently allows up to 15 headlines and 4 descriptions per RSA. Assets may appear in different orders, so each asset needs to make sense on its own and when combined with others. Ad Strength is a diagnostic about the relationship and variety of assets; it is not a complete evaluation of the landing page or business offer.

- Headline set covers the main search intent, product/service, benefit, credibility, and call to action without repeating the same idea.
- Descriptions explain what the visitor can expect after the click and avoid unsupported claims.
- Final URL matches the ad promise and the intended conversion path.
- Sitelinks and other eligible assets are relevant, accurate, and lead to useful destinations.
- Legal disclaimers, prices, conditions, trademarks, and promotions are consistent with the landing page.

5. Conversion tracking and measurement

Conversion measurement is where many campaigns quietly go wrong. Google Ads distinguishes primary conversion actions, which can appear in the Conversions column and be used for bidding when their goal is selected, from secondary actions that are generally observation-only. Make the conversion architecture match the business outcome before automated bidding is asked to learn from it.

- Every intended conversion action is named clearly and mapped to the correct source.
- Primary vs. secondary status is intentional; micro-actions such as scroll depth, page view, or generic engagement are not accidentally treated as the main business outcome.
- For lead generation, the setup distinguishes a lead submission from a qualified lead or sale when the business has a way to import downstream outcomes.
- Phone calls, forms, purchases, or other meaningful actions are tested end to end.
- Google Tag / conversion tags or imported analytics conversions are firing as expected.
- Conversion values are used only when they represent something meaningful enough to support value-based reporting or bidding.
- UTM parameters and analytics attribution are consistent with the organization naming standard.

6. Landing page readiness

Google defines the landing page as the page people reach after clicking an ad and notes that landing-page experience includes usefulness and relevance, ease of navigation, and whether the page meets expectations created by the ad. Google also recommends regularly reviewing landing-page performance and emphasizes mobile speed and usability.

- Ad headline/message and landing-page headline clearly relate to the same offer or intent.
- The primary action is visible without making the visitor search for it.
- Content answers the practical questions a buyer needs answered before taking the next step.
- Forms, phone links, checkout, scheduling, or purchase flows work on mobile and desktop.
- No unexpected redirects, interstitials, broken images, mixed-content warnings, or destination mismatch issues.
- Page loads quickly enough to avoid unnecessary abandonment; important content appears early.
- Privacy, contact, refund, shipping, licensing, or other applicable information is easy to find.

7. Policy and trust review

- Claims in ad copy are accurate and supportable.
- Landing-page content does not hide material terms, misrepresent the business, or create a misleading impression.
- Products, services, pricing, promotions, and availability are represented consistently.
- Any regulated category, trademark, financial, health, housing, employment, political, or other special policy requirements have been reviewed as applicable.
- Domain, display URL, and final URL are consistent with the destination requirements for the campaign.

8. Budget, bidding, and launch controls

- Budget is high enough to generate useful observations relative to the chosen market, while still being affordable for the business.

- Bidding strategy matches the maturity of the conversion data and the objective. Do not expect an automated strategy to fix a poorly configured conversion signal.
- Bid targets, budgets, and conversion goals have a change-management plan for the first learning period.
- Launch dates, ad schedules, and business availability line up.
- Someone is responsible for the first review and knows what data will be examined before changes are made.

Launch-day QA

- Search the landing page yourself from a clean session and complete the intended conversion.
- Click every active ad/asset and confirm the correct destination.
- Check mobile rendering on a real device when possible.
- Confirm conversions appear in the expected system before spending is scaled.
- Capture the initial campaign settings so later changes can be explained.
- Write down the first review date and the specific questions that review must answer.

Current Google documentation

As of September 2026, Google documentation describes the current workflow around keyword matching, responsive search ads, landing pages, conversion actions, and search-term analysis. Recheck the live account because Google can change interface labels and recommendations.

Post-launch review: what should you learn?

A launch is not the end of the checklist. It is the start of the evidence. The first reviews should concentrate on whether the campaign is attracting the intended searches, whether people understand the offer after the click, whether conversions are real, and whether the measurement setup is telling the truth.

- Which search themes actually triggered ads?
- Are irrelevant queries showing up repeatedly?
- Which ads and assets are attracting the right kind of traffic?
- Are landing pages producing the intended actions?
- Are conversions being recorded once, accurately, and under the correct goal?
- Is the business able to respond to leads or fulfill purchases at the expected pace?
- What single change would most clearly test the next hypothesis?

Sources

About keyword matching options

<https://support.google.com/google-ads/answer/7478529>

About responsive search ads

<https://support.google.com/google-ads/answer/7684791>

Landing page

<https://support.google.com/google-ads/answer/14086>

Evaluate the performance of your landing pages

<https://support.google.com/google-ads/answer/7543502>

About primary and secondary conversion actions

<https://support.google.com/google-ads/answer/11461796>

About conversion measurement

<https://support.google.com/google-ads/answer/1722022>

About the search terms report

<https://support.google.com/google-ads/answer/2472708>